

TECHNOLOGY GUIDE

Migrating Your Front Desk System Without Downtime

A step-by-step plan for switching property management systems without a single missed reservation.

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For: hoteliers switching from a legacy PMS or spreadsheets

Published by XYVOO — hotel management and storefront software. This guide is provided for general information and reflects practices we've seen work across the properties and shops we support; treat figures and thresholds as a starting point to adapt to your own operation.

Why hoteliers put this off

Switching front desk software is usually the right call and almost always delayed, because the property can't afford a night where check-in doesn't work. That fear is reasonable — but it's a planning problem, not a reason to stay on a system that's costing you time and repeat guests. Done in the right order, a migration has no guest-facing downtime at all.

The four-phase plan

Phase 1 — Audit (1–2 weeks before go-live)

- ☐ Export every future reservation from your current system, including special requests and deposits already taken.
- ☐ List every room type, rate plan and tax rule exactly as it exists today — don't redesign your rate structure at the same time as your software.
- ☐ Identify every integration in use today (payment terminal, channel manager, door locks) and confirm the new system supports each one.
- ☐ Agree a single go-live date with your whole team, ideally on a low-occupancy weekday, never mid-weekend.

Phase 2 — Parallel setup (the week before)

This is the phase that removes almost all the risk: the new system is built and checked while the old one keeps running the property, so nothing depends on the new system yet.

- ☐ Load room types, rates and tax rules into the new system and check a sample folio calculates correctly against a known example from the old system.
- ☐ Import future reservations and check every one against the original export — names, dates, rate, deposit.
- ☐ Run the payment integration in test mode and confirm a transaction reconciles correctly on both sides.
- ☐ Train the front desk team on the new system using real (already-checked) reservation data, not a demo account.

Phase 3 — Go-live (the day itself)

- ☐ Freeze new bookings in the old system from the night before go-live, so nothing gets created there after the export.
 - ☐ Re-import any reservations taken in that overnight window before opening the new system to the front desk.
 - ☐ Keep the old system available, read-only, for at least two weeks — for looking up historic folios, not for new activity.
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- ☐ Have one person on shift, day one, whose only job is watching the new system for anything unexpected — not covering the desk themselves.

Phase 4 — Stabilise (the first two weeks)

- ☐ Reconcile the first week's payments against your processor's settlement report line by line, not just the total.
- ☐ Check every channel (OTA, direct, phone) is still delivering reservations into the new system correctly.
- ☐ Collect one list of 'things the old system did that this doesn't yet' from the team, and work through it as a short punch-list rather than letting it become a reason to go back.

What actually causes downtime

In our experience, near-misses come from a small, predictable set of causes:

Reservations taken in the last 24–48 hours before go-live and never re-imported.

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THE ONE RULE THAT MATTERS MOST

Never let two systems both believe they're the one taking new bookings at the same time. Everything else in this guide exists to make that single moment — the freeze and cutover — as short and clean as possible.

How XYVOO helps

XYVOO's onboarding team runs the audit and parallel-setup phases with you, including a side-by-side folio check against your existing system before go-live, so the switch itself is a formality rather than a leap of faith.
